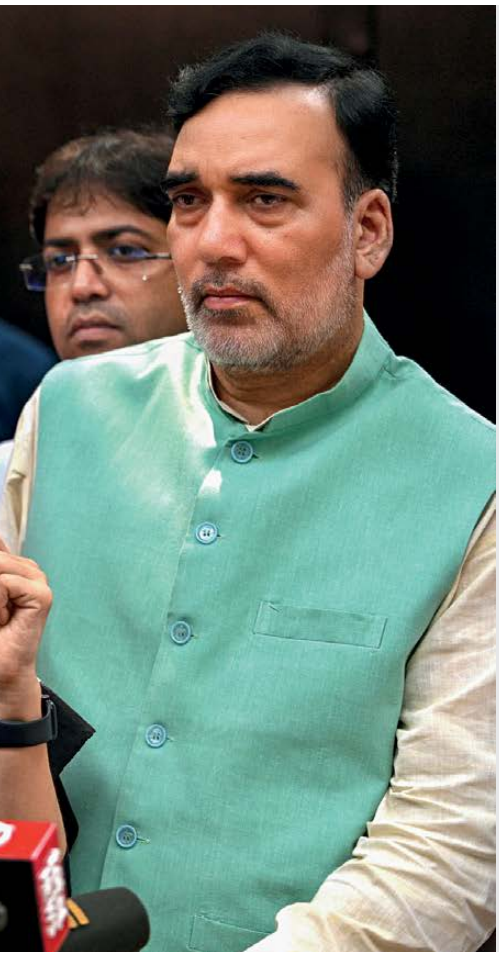


Not now. "Manish, too, has made a certificate of honesty" from the people a precondition for returning to office, says Kejriwal.

The AAP game plan is clear. Kejriwal, Sisodia and other senior leaders like Saurabh Bharadwaj ill mobilise its core base among Delhi's urban poor. Atishi, meanwhile, will put up a show of continuity. The party's main priority will be to speed up the implementation of schemes like the Mukhyamantri Mahila Samman Yojana—a Rs 1,000 monthly assistance for women—targeting the 6.7 million female voters in the capital.

The new CM has been a Kejriwal loyalist through and through. An academic overachiever (St Stephen's College in Delhi and Oxford, where she was a Rhodes scholar), Atishi's political graph has seen a spectacular rise in AAP and in the Delhi government. In the absence of Sisodia and other senior leaders, the 43-year-old first-time MLA had been entrusted with 13 departments, including finance, public works and education, the all-important ministries in AAP's scheme of things. "I come from an ordinary family. Had I been in any other party, I would not even have got an election ticket. But Kejriwalji trusted me, made me an MLA, made me a minister, and today has given me the responsibility of (being) the chief minister," she said after receiving the party's mandate.

Delhi has 14.7 million voters, of which some 45 per cent are women. A section of the party believes Atishi's ascension is timely for two reasons—she hasn't been tainted by allegations and will address two constituencies, women voters and the middle-class electorate that may be a tad disenchanted with AAP. In the recent local ward committee elections of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, the BJP won seven of the 12 municipal zones; AAP managed only five.

The BJP has already sharpened its claws. "She is part of the same corrupt cabinet that has looted the people of Delhi," BJP state president Virendra Sachdeva said at a presser the day Atishi took over. Meanwhile, former AAP legislator and BJP rabble-rouser Kapil Mishra has been going on about Atishi's parents—who are retired Delhi University professors and Leftist sympathisers—signing a clemency petition for "terrorist" Afzal Guru, the 2001 Parliament attack accused who was hanged in 2013.

AAP's Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal, who has had a falling out with the party, has also released a video repeating the same charges. "It is an unfortunate day for Delhi," she has said. AAP's instant rebut is that Maliwal is acting out a script written by the BJP. "If she has any shame left, she should resign from the Rajya Sabha and seek a ticket from the BJP," party MLA Dilip Pandey retorted. The BJP has also taken to social media to accuse Atishi of being a 'Marxist-Leninist'—a throwback to her surname Marlena, a portmanteau of Marx and Lenin.

But this is just the beginning; the attacks on the new CM will only get sharper as the election nears. Atishi would be well advised to proceed cautiously, heed the example of Delhi's first woman CM, the late Sushma Swaraj, and her brief 52-day stint. Swaraj had been sent in just before the 1998 assembly poll, at the fag end of a BJP regime mired in corruption, only to face the ire of the people over, of all things, the 'skyrocketing prices of onions'. That did not end well. AAP will be hoping Atishi's time in the hot seat yields a much more pleasant outcome. ■

The Kejri Chronicle

MARCH 21, 2024: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrests Arvind Kejriwal for alleged money laundering in Delhi excise policy case

APRIL 2: AAP's Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh, in jail since October 2023, gets bail

MAY 10: SC grants Kejriwal interim bail, allows him to campaign for general election

JUNE 1: After interim bail expires, the AAP supremo surrenders at Tihar jail

JUNE 26: The CBI formally arrests him on corruption charges

JULY 12: SC grants bail in the ED case, but Kejriwal remains in jail in the CBI arrest

AUG. 9: AAP No. 2 Manish Sisodia gets bail after about a year and a half in jail

SEPT. 13: SC grants Kejriwal bail in CBI case but with conditions

SEPT. 17: Kejriwal resigns as CM, nominates Atishi